



LOOKING OUTWARD
The industry is heavily dependent on other countries for accessories and components

PHOTO BY MANEESH AGNIHOTRI

SME SPECIAL LEATHER

HIDE AND SEEK

DESPITE SURGING DEMAND FOR LEATHER AND LEATHER PRODUCT EXPORTS, KANPUR'S TANNERY OWNERS ARE STRUGGLING TO OVERCOME SEVERAL CHALLENGES

BY RAJAT MISHRA

HEAPS OF LEATHER are stacked over one another, and an overpowering, pungent smell from a concoction of chemicals hangs in the air at Homera Tanning Industries' office in Jajmau area of Kanpur. Asad Rizwan, one of the founders of the company, is busy checking the quality of leather produced at his tannery, where raw hides are converted into leather. "Nubuck leather, aniline leather, and burnishable leather are good quality leather, while haircell leather is a mid-range leather," Rizwan tells someone on the phone, ensconced comfortably in his corner room. On this reporter's query, he gazes out the window and says, "The leather industry in Kanpur is booming post the pandemic. That is reflected in the strong order book of the companies. But in this industry, quality is key. Whoever will ace the game of producing quality products will grow by leaps and bounds."

Jajmau is home to more than 200 tanneries like Homera, with a combined processing capacity of 18,000 hides daily. According to one tannery owner, Kanpur contributes roughly 30 per cent to the leather trade in India, accounting for around ₹6,000 crore